

now going for their second child in Anand, this time by another local woman. Says Thomas, "The ease with which Brady was born and the cost we paid for making our lives meaningful are simply unthinkable in the US."

Anand has in fact become, literally, a cradle for surrogate mothers in India, thanks to Akanksha, which specialises in in-vitro fertilisation (IVF). Patel, fondly known as Nainaben, has facilitated the birth of 35 babies through surrogate mothers in her clinic since 2003, when the first surrogate mother delivered. The number of successful surrogate deliveries in Anand is the highest in the world. It was this achievement and the pressing need for

childless couples—is always longer than the second despite more and more women taking up surrogacy. Once a candidate is chosen by a couple, they sign a legal contract with her covering the details of payment. The semen and eggs of the couple are then collected, fertilised in the clinic laboratory, and then injected into the uterus of the surrogate. Within 15 days, it becomes clear if the woman will conceive or not. If she doesn't—the success rate is 50 per cent—the candidate gets a nominal amount from the couple as per the contract. On conception, she gets Rs 2.5 lakh, in addition to a monthly amount of Rs 3,000 that the couple spend on the pregnancy in order to

delivery, which helped her and her husband Jagdish, a delivery boy in a courier company, build a small house of their own. Pushpa says she will use the proceeds from the second delivery to educate her daughter Jinal, a bright Class III student who wants to be a doctor. Says Pushpa, "When I first decided to become a surrogate last year, I became an outcast among friends and family. But an article by Nainaben in a local newspaper, describing scientifically what surrogate motherhood is, and the resultant enhancement in my financial status due to the money I earned, changed all that. Surrogacy has suddenly become acceptable to everyone." Her husband has been sup-



❶ **THE PIONEER** Gynaecologist and Akanksha Fertility Clinic founder Naina Patel (centre) holding a newborn, with women who have opted for surrogate motherhood

❷ **FUTURE PERFECT** Thomas and Karen Kim, an American couple of South Korean origin, with their child Brady and Patel

❸ **MOTHER'S PRIDE** Regina Malik, the surrogate mother who delivered Brady early last year. She has rented a flat in Anand, where she now takes care of women who have taken up surrogacy in secret.

❹ **A BETTER LIFE** Thirty-year-old Manjula Chakranarayan, a maidservant who is pregnant with the child of a Sindhi couple from Jammu and Kashmir

surrogate mothers in the US that prompted New York's ABC Television to interview Patel on its show, *Good Morning America*. With 42 surrogate mothers now carrying the embryos of childless couples—among them Americans, Germans, Taiwanese, Korean and Israeli couples, besides NRIs and locals—there is little doubt that Anand, which also heralded the milk revolution, is all set to lead a revolution in surrogate motherhood.

The system in place at her clinic, which Patel set up in 1999, is fairly simple. Those wanting a child get themselves registered and so do the women who wish to take up surrogacy. The first list—which now comprises 250

get a healthy child.

Mark, 54, and Darcy Cornwell, 39, an American couple, attempted to beget a child through an Anand surrogate, but the woman carrying the couple's sperm and eggs failed to conceive. However, they have not given up. Says Patel, "A second try generally doesn't fail. That's our experience."

An analysis of some cases of surrogate motherhood in Akanksha Clinic shows how a highly sensitive concept has become acceptable now. Take the example of Pushpa Pandya, 27, who gave birth to a child for a Bangalore-based couple last year and is now carrying the child of an NRI couple based in the US. She got Rs 2.5 lakh for the first

portive. "Once we spoke to Nainaben, we were convinced there was no moral question involved in it," he says.

Then there is Manjula Chakranarayan, 30, a maidservant earning just Rs 50-100 a day, who is pregnant with the child of a Sindhi couple from Jammu and Kashmir. "We are fed up of poverty. This is the best way to lead a better life. All my relatives know about it. They say that if I am doing it for my children, there's nothing wrong in it," she says.

However, not every surrogate mother has had it so easy. Fear of social boycott has forced Jagruti Rathod, wife of an autorickshaw driver from Vadodara, to keep her surrogate preg-